

Preston R. Johnston

PhD Candidate
MIT Department of Political Science
Building E53-420

+1 (615) 574-4820
prhj@mit.edu
prestonjohnston.com

Research interests

Climate politics; climate adaptation policy and behavior; American political institutions; insurance; money in politics; causal inference

Education

Massachusetts Institute of Technology (2021-)

PhD Candidate, Political Science
Primary field: Political Economy. *Secondary field:* Quantitative Methods
Grade: 4.0/4.0

Princeton University (2017-2021)

A.B. in Politics (*magna cum laude*)
Certificate in Statistics and Machine Learning
Grade: 3.83/4.0

Dissertation project

Working title: *Paying for Climate Change: The Politics of Insurance in a Warming World*

Dissertation committee: Kathleen Thelen (Chair; MIT), Evan S. Lieberman (MIT), Devin Caughey (MIT), Leah Stokes (UCSB)

Working papers

**indicates dissertation paper*

Resisting Segmentation: Climate risk and the politics of insurance* (*Job market paper*)

Voters Uncovered: Home insurance availability, electoral backlash, and climate adaptation* *Conditionally accepted at the Journal of Political Institutions and Political Economy*

Ethnicity and Climate Attitudes in Africa (with Evan S. Lieberman and Devin Caughey). *Under review.*

Work in progress

Swimming in the Flood? Ideology and individual-level climate adaptation in Brazil (with Clemente T. Sanchez)

Homeowner resistance to climate adaptation: Evidence from wildfire risk in Oregon (with Brice Green, Janet Malzahn, Andy McEvoy, and Chris Dunn)

Pulling the Fire Alarm? Insurer corporate behavior under climate change

The Role of Business in Democratic Backsliding in the United States (with Kathleen Thelen and Alex Hertel-Fernandez)

The Politics of Reinsurance Pools in the UK and Australia*

Teaching

Teaching assistance:

MIT Poli Sci 17.802 Quantitative Research Methods II: Causal Inference (graduate; Prof. Daniel Hidalgo)	Spring 2025
MIT Poli Sci 17.20 Introduction to American Politics (undergraduate; Prof. Devin Caughey)	Fall 2024

Workshops and miscellaneous:

Global Diversity Lab Pathways Program: "How to read a quantitative social science paper."	Summer 2024; Summer 2025
Taught three class sessions for MIT Poli Sci 17.571 Democracy, Development, and Climate Change in Africa (undergraduate; Prof. Evan S. Lieberman)	Spring 2026

Conferences and workshop presentations

2026:

- American Political Science Association (**APSA**). September 2026 in Boston, MA. (*Upcoming*). For "Resisting Segmentation."
- American Political Science Association (**APSA**). September 2026 in Boston, MA. (*Upcoming*). For "Homeowner resistance to climate adaptation."
- Political Economy of Climate and the Environment (**PECE**). September 2026 in Boston, MA. (*Upcoming*). For "Resisting Segmentation."
- Consortium on the American Political Economy (**CAPE**) Summer Research Conference. July 2026. Virtual. (*Upcoming*). For "Resisting Segmentation."
- Princeton-Copenhagen Business School Money in Politics Conference. June 2026 in Copenhagen, Denmark. For "Resisting Segmentation."
- The New Political Economy of Welfare Systems in Times of Climate Change. June 2026 at Sciences Po in Paris, France. For "The Politics of Reinsurance Pools in the UK and Australia."
- Consortium on the American Political Economy (**CAPE**) Summer Academy (selected participant). May-June 2026 at UC Berkeley. For "Resisting Segmentation."
- Climate Pipeline Conference. May 2026 at Columbia University. For "Resisting Segmentation."
- Climate Pipeline Conference. May 2026 at Columbia University. For "Swimming in the Flood."

2025:

- Political Institutions and Political Economy collaborative (**PIPE**). December 2025 at the University of Southern California. For "Voters Uncovered."
- American Political Science Association (**APSA**). September 2025 in Vancouver, BC, Canada. For "Pulling the Fire Alarm?"
- Political Economy and Welfare Research Network Early Career Workshop. June 2025 at Temple University. For "Resisting Segmentation."
- Council for European Studies (**CES**) International Conference of Europeanists. June 2025 in Philadelphia, PA. Invited moderator and discussant for panel titled "The Green Firm." Also accepted as part of proposed panel, "Evolving Welfare States in Times of New Social Risks."
- MIT Center for International Studies Global Climate Adaptation Workshop. April 2025 in Cambridge, MA. Invited participant in panel titled "Climate Negotiations and the Most Vulnerable: Toward COP 30 in Brazil." Presented "Swimming in the Flood."

2024:

- Seminar on State and Capitalism Since 1800. December 2024 at Harvard University. Invited discussant for Charnysh et al. "Place Not Race: Identities, Social Proximity and the Global Climate Emergency."
- American Political Science Association (**APSA**). September 2024 in Philadelphia, PA. For "Ethnicity and Climate Dissensus in Africa."
- Midwest Political Science Association (**MPSA**). April 2024 in Chicago, IL.
- Working Group in African Political Economy (**WGAPE**). March 2024 in Accra, Ghana. For "Ethnicity and Climate Dissensus in Africa."

*Regular attendee at the Political Economy of Climate and the Environment (**PECE**), Northeast Workshop in Empirical Political Science (**NEWEPS**), Consortium on the American Political Economy (**CAPE**) summer research conference, among others.*

Grants and awards

- MIT CIS PhD Student Summer Research Grant (\$5,000) for fieldwork in Australia 2025
- Walter A. Rosenblith Presidential Fellow (MIT) 2021-2023

Service

- Co-organizer, Yale-MIT Graduate Student Workshop on Home Insurance and Climate Spring 2026
- Co-organizer, MIT Comparative Politics and Political Economy Workshop 2024 - 2026
- Graduate Student Council department social chair 2022 - 2024
- Reviewer for: *American Journal of Political Science*

Research experience

Research assistance:

Prof. Kathleen Thelen (MIT) and Alex Hertel-Fernandez (Columbia)	Fall 2025 - Spring 2026 (ongoing)
Prof. Evan S. Lieberman (MIT)	Summer 2022; Summer 2023 - Spring 2024; Summer 2025
Prof. Chenzi Xu (Stanford economics)	Summer 2020 - Summer 2021
Prof. Leonard Wantchekon (Princeton)	Summer 2021
Prof. Matias Iaryczower (Princeton)	Summer 2019; Fall 2020

References

Professor Kathleen Thelen
kthelen@mit.edu

Professor Evan S. Lieberman
evanlieb@mit.edu

Professor Devin Caughey
caughey@mit.edu